

The Naneghat Cave, on the walls of which the Satavahana queen Naganika carved a series of family portraits and a detailed account of her late husband’s and her own religious sacrifices.

National Highway 222 follows an ancient trade route running inland from the Konkan coast just north of modern Mumbai. If you stay on the road it will take you to Ahmednagar, but a point comes when you see ahead of you what looks like an unbroken line of cliffs topped here and there by jagged peaks. To avoid these cliffs the metalled road veers to the north-west, and it is precisely at this point that it deviates from the old track, which now has to be followed on foot. The trail winds through paddy fields and across little rivulets for a couple of hours’ walking before you arrive at the foot of the cliff-wall, which at this point sticks out to form a crescent-shaped bastion with a distinct cleft in the middle. You now have to climb, an ascent that grows increasingly precipitous until the path gives way to uneven steps cut directly into the rock. Above and to your right you can see two tiers of caves crudely cut into the cliff-face, the nearest of which has been shored up with some